Westbrook City Council

~ Special Meeting ~

Date: Monday, January 12, 2026
Time: 7:00 PM
Location: Westbrook High School (Room 114), 125 Stroudwater St.
Video: https://vimeo.com/1153765198
Packet: https://www.westbrookmaine.gov/AgendaCenter/ViewFile/Agenda/_01122026-981

Timestamps below are clickable [0:00]-style links — they jump straight to that moment in the video.

This summary highlights the meeting's key discussions and decisions, with direct quotes and timestamps for verification — it is not a substitute for watching the full meeting. *Summarization necessarily condenses and selects; for complete context, nuance, and anything not covered here, watch the full video at the link above. (Produced by: WestbrookCurrents.com)*

Mayor's Message

Remarks on Minneapolis, Immigrant Neighbors & Holiday Lights [0:04]

Discussion Summary

Mayor David Morse opened by acknowledging the recent Minneapolis police killing, saying he was “still processing it” like many residents, and reiterated a message of support for Westbrook's immigrant neighbors: “I don't feel safer because of ICE... I feel safe when my community and my neighbors are coming together.”

Holiday lights: the city has spent an estimated $180,000 since 2017 upgrading the holiday light display; the downtown TIF separately paid about $88,000 for the animated tree (2021); 2023 and 2024 each saw a ~$25,000 operating-budget boost to enhance the display; the city now spends about $5,000 annually on replacement bulbs/strands, driven largely by vandalism (roughly 20 strands cut per year).

Key Decisions

✓ Informational — no vote taken.

Action Items

None.

PFAS Update — Credere Associates Presentation

[8:12] Informational presentation on three city-owned parcels — Cornelia Warren Field, a field referred to as Fraser Field, and the Westbrook High School field — which received biosolids under mid-1980s permits and may contain PFAS (field names as spoken in the recording; the packet's PFAS slides are images, not extractable text).

Rip Patton (Credere Associates, the City's Brownfields Qualified Environmental Professional) and Deputy Director of Economic & Community Development Monique Cornett briefed the Council. Project Manager Robyn Saunders gave an initial presentation in January 2025; since then the city confirmed a permit existed for biosolid spreading at these sites but found no documentation confirming it occurred, or how extensively. Maine DEP ranks known PFAS sludge sites Tier 1–4 by documented volume; these three are unranked/Tier 4 (not a current DEP priority) because no sludge-spreading has been confirmed.

The City's EPA Brownfields assessment grant turned out to be ineligible for this work, because the city already owned the parcels when the alleged spreading occurred. Greater Portland Council of Governments (GPCOG) Brownfields funds look viable instead, pending an eligibility review (~2 months). If approved, proposed work includes incremental sampling methodology (ISM) across each site's surface plus discrete soil borings at depth (geoprobe, backfilled the same day), at roughly $800 per boring — drilling/sampling in March–April, lab analysis (3 weeks), and a report (2 weeks), with results expected around May 2026.

> *"We talk about this in such scientific terms, but we never really discussed what it actually can cause and can mean to a human or an animal... it's kind of shocking to me that there's kind of a blasé attitude toward PFAS from the city administration. It's very harmful."*

— Councilor Anna Turcotte [22:50]

Patton acknowledged PFAS is a suspected (not EPA-confirmed) carcinogen linked to liver-function and other health effects, but distinguished the soil testing proposed here from direct ingestion risk such as PFAS in drinking water. Councilor Faulkingham asked whether a high concentration finding would raise these sites' DEP tier; Patton said he'd assume so but wasn't certain.

Key Decisions

✓ Informational — no vote taken.

Council Messages

Assistant City Administrator Posting, Presumpscot 2040 & Community Food Pantry [30:39]

Discussion Summary

Councilor Gary Rairdon objected to the City posting an Assistant City Administrator position, noting the duties were previously split into the current City Administrator's role as a succession plan; he asked the administration to withdraw the posting and said he'd revisit the position during the next budget review.

Vice President Michael Shaughnessy announced "Presumpscot 2040," a public-input process on the Presumpscot River (water quality, recreation, habitat, culture) run by the Casco Bay Estuary Partnership and facilitated by Craig Freshley, with two public sessions on Feb. 2, 2026 at the Westbrook Community Center (2:30–5:00 PM and 6:30–9:00 PM).

President Jennifer Munro echoed the Mayor's remarks on the national mood and highlighted a new free food pantry, "Cater to Community," at Mr. Bagel on Main Street.

Key Decisions

✓ Informational — no vote taken.

Action Items

None.

Public Comment (First)

[34:37] Extensive public comment, almost entirely about Order 2026-02 (rifle suppressors, see next section) and, briefly, the separate Dory Schollberger/12 Water Street matter.

Daniel Peterson (34 Garfield St.)

Spoke on LD 1829 and the Dory Schollberger/12 Water Street matter, then cautioned the Mayor and Council against any implication of opposing federal law enforcement in their remarks on immigration: “We don't want Minneapolis to happen here... we who believe in legal immigration but oppose illegal immigration, we don't want that [either].” Not discussed further by the Council on the record.

Four letters were read into the record by the Clerk: Amanda Hollander (69 Falmouth St., Ward 4), John Scribner (on the Water Street matter, unrelated to the suppressor order), Mary Tardiff (35 Middle St., Ward 2), and Carrie Tyson (237 Bridge St., a U.S. Air Force veteran) — see the Order 2026-02 section below for the substance.

Orders of the Day — Second & Final Reading

Orders 2026-03, 2026-04 — CCTV Software Subscription & Replacement Tractor (Consent) [54:41]

Discussion Summary

Moved together by Councilor Rairdon; President Munro pulled Order 2026-02 (rifle suppressors) out for separate debate, covered next. Order 2026-03 authorizes purchase of CCTV inspection software; Order 2026-04 authorizes replacement of a utility tractor. No discussion on either.

Key Decisions

✓ Both approved together by unanimous roll call, 7–0.

Action Items

None.

Order 2026-02 — Rifle Suppressors for the Police Department

*[54:21] Second and final reading (first reading passed 6–0 on Jan. 5, 2026). Purchases 50 rifle suppressors for a combined price of **$24,405.50**, paid entirely from the Police Department's federal forfeiture funds (no local tax dollars). Note: the packet's narrative memo names the vendor as Energetic Armament/Energetic Arms of Mattapoisett, MA, but the order's own legal text and itemized quote list — which matches the final $24,405.50 total exactly — name the low bidder as Summit Sound Technologies, LLC, also of Mattapoisett, MA. This inconsistency exists in the City's own packet and is noted here, not resolved.*

Public opposition

> *“Not a single U.S. military branch utilizes suppressors for weapon system validation... Suppressors are provided only to Tier One special operations units in the military in order to prevent muzzle flash in combat zones... This feels as if we are further trending toward the continued militarization of our police force under the guise of enhancing PPE.”*

— Lucas Schrage (33 Cloudman St., public comment) [45:24]

> *“I don't want our cops to look like ICE and I don't want them to start using the tactics of ICE... I have not had a clear sidewalk a single day this year... I have to imagine that it wouldn't take too many silencers['-worth of funds] to pay for just clearing the snow on the sidewalks.”*

— Jeremy Niles (67 Lyman St., public comment) [48:03]

> *“Studies do show that when police forces have more militarized equipment, that they're more likely to have violent encounters with the public, irrespective of local crime rates... I think all gun accessories... I see them as toys for men.”*

— Oriana Farnum (67 Lyman St., public comment) [51:14]

Four letters were also read into the record. Three (Amanda Hollander, Mary Tardiff, and U.S. Air Force veteran Carrie Tyson) opposed or conditioned support on the order, questioning the $24,405.50 price, the need for 50 units, and whether cheaper hearing-protection alternatives existed; a fourth, from John Scribner, was on the unrelated Water Street matter.

Councilor Turcotte's rebuttal

> *“Let me assure you, as a former refugee and someone who's lived outside of this country, that... America is [not] the only country where police use[s] force. That is incorrect... What happened in Minneapolis... is completely unrelated to the police department that we have in this city... I am also very hesitant to believe that this is about cost. We had paid more for the leather chairs at the library than these suppressors... Let's not pretend that this is about cost or it is about Minneapolis. This is a different kind of agenda. I don't appreciate it. You guys should come out and say what actually is on your minds.”*

— Councilor Anna Turcotte [56:44]

> *“Guns are there, especially within the police department, [to] protect us from criminals, protect our children from school shooters... I don't know what kind of world you live in, but I appreciate all those men with guns that protect us.”*

— Councilor Anna Turcotte [1:10:28]

Chief Sean Lally's explanation

The department has 49 officers, each issued a personally zeroed rifle, plus one spare — hence 50 units. Lally drew a firm distinction between suppressors, which reduce but don't eliminate noise (roughly 25–40 decibels off a ~160-decibel unsuppressed rifle), and movie-style “silencers,” which don't exist for rifles. He cited his own military-service hearing loss as part of his motivation and framed the purchase as personal protective equipment rather than militarization, noting the department deliberately avoids armored vehicles and similar gear. He disclosed that Westbrook officers on the Cumberland County Emergency Services Unit, a regional tactical team, already carry Westbrook-owned, suppressor-equipped rifles on the street weekly; rank-and-file officers currently train with rifles only twice a year (June and October/November) due to budget limits. He noted the Eleanor Ave. range has drawn noise complaints from abutters. Councilor Faulkingham asked whether this is standard elsewhere; Lally and Rairdon said Lewiston and Gorham PD either have or are acquiring suppressors, as does the Cumberland County Sheriff's Department.

> *“I don't really see a benefit to having it be less quiet in a neighborhood if there is actual gunfire. If there's gonna be gunfire in a neighborhood, I wanna know — to stay away, to stay indoors.”*

— President Jennifer Munro [1:05:36]

President Munro pressed further on federal-forfeiture-fund spending rules; Lally confirmed the funds can cover firearms/accessories but not salaries or supplanting budgeted positions, and that the department is audited annually with a full inventory requirement. Councilors Shaughnessy and Chau both described themselves as

conflicted given “the times we're in” but ultimately supportive after Lally's explanation — Chau said he was “supporting this based on the safety impact on the officers, not on anything else.” Councilor McCambridge asked whether this would increase training frequency (Lally: he'd like somewhat more, but range access/cost is limiting).

Key Decisions

✓ Order 2026-02 passed [1:23:21] 6–1, with President Munro the lone dissenting vote.

New Business (continued)

Resolve 2026-03 — Election Clerks (2026–2027) [1:23:32]

Found on page 28 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Moved by Councilor Rairdon under 21-A M.R.S.A. §503, as recommended by the City Clerk and Registrar of Voters.

Key Decisions

✓ Approved by unanimous roll call, 7–0.

Action Items

None.

Resolve 2026-04 — Zoning Board of Appeals — Cliff McCarthy [1:25:00]

Found on page 33 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Confirms Mayor Morse's appointment of Cliff McCarthy, an experienced appellate attorney and recent Ward 4 transplant, as an alternate ZBA member for the remainder of a three-year term expiring Dec. 31, 2026.

Key Decisions

✓ Approved by unanimous roll call, 7–0.

Action Items

None.

Resolve 2026-05 — LD 1829 — Housing Density [1:27:01]

Found on page 36 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Read by title only at Councilor Chau's request, since the Council had discussed it at length at a prior meeting. Councilor Rairdon confirmed on the record that a “yes” vote sends a message to Westbrook's legislative delegation supporting amendments toward the resolve's stated goals, not a binding local change.

Key Decisions

✓ Approved by unanimous roll call, 7–0.

Action Items

None.

Order 2026-05 — Criminal Forfeiture Asset — Ruger AR-15 Rifle [1:28:51]

Found on page 46 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Approves transfer of a Ruger AR-15 rifle (serial no. 85387398), forfeited to the department via a Cumberland County Unified Criminal Court drug-trafficking/overdose-death case (Docket No. CR-22-744), for continued PD use rather than destruction. Chief Lally explained the department typically destroys non-usable forfeited firearms (roughly 100–150 last year) but adopts serviceable, matching-caliber weapons like this one to avoid a roughly $1,500 replacement purchase; he said the department is otherwise well-stocked on rifles for the next 5–10 years.

Key Decisions

✓ Approved 6–0 (Councilor Faulkingham briefly absent from this vote).

Action Items

None.

Order 2026-06 — Credere Associates Task Order No. 7 — Riverwalk North Survey (First Reading) [1:33:58]

Found on page 51 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Authorizes a $36,100 update to the City's 2015 Riverwalk North topographic survey, via subcontractor Owen Haskell, Inc. of Falmouth, ME — needed because a wetland/invasive-species assessment, floodplain changes, and regulatory updates have occurred since 2015.

Key Decisions

✓ Passed first reading, unanimous roll call, 6–0.

Action Items

None.

Order 2026-07 — Sigma Tactical Wellness Health & Wellness Screenings (First Reading) [1:35:26]

Found on page 55 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Authorizes an agreement, up to $41,000, with Sigma Tactical Wellness (Austin, TX) for voluntary health and wellness screenings — a carotid intima-media thickness ultrasound, a cardiac stress test, and a telehealth consult with a healthcare provider — for police, fire, and dispatch personnel. Primarily funded through a Maine Department of Public Safety grant (Order 2025-114), with the balance split between the Fire Department's medical-exam line and the Police Department's federal forfeiture line. Fire Chief Stephen Sloan explained the screening menu in response to Councilor Chau's question.

Key Decisions

✓ Passed first reading, unanimous roll call, 6–0.

Action Items

None.

Closing

Public Comment (Second), Referrals & Adjournment [1:40:17]

Discussion Summary

No further public comment; no referrals or committee reports.

Key Decisions

✓ Motion to adjourn approved by unanimous roll call, 6–0.

Action Items

None.

How this was made

This summary was produced from the meeting video (linked above, hosted on the City's Vimeo showcase). The audio was downloaded with Downie 4 and transcribed with speaker diarization using MacWhisper. Claude (Anthropic's AI) cross-checked names and figures against the official packet and the city council roster, attributed speakers from context (introductions, roll-call order, direct address by the presiding officer) rather than the raw diarization labels alone, and drafted this summary and the quoted excerpts. Quotes are lightly cleaned of filler words/false starts but not reworded. Review tier: Not reviewed.

Produced by Westbrook Currents — westbrookcurrents.com